

How to Analyze a Job Description

CareerForge Knowledge Base · Volume 2

Why this matters: A job description is a compressed brief of what the hiring manager actually needs. Reading it carefully -- before you touch your resume or apply -- is the highest-leverage 10 minutes in a job search.

1. Separate Requirements Into Three Tiers

- **Must-haves (dealbreakers):** Usually phrased as "required", "X+ years of", or listed first. If you're missing more than one or two of these, tailor your application to explicitly address the gap rather than ignoring it.
- **Nice-to-haves (differentiators):** Phrased as "preferred", "bonus", or "a plus". These are useful for tie-breaking between candidates -- mention them if you have them, don't worry if you don't.
- **Implied requirements (unwritten but expected):** Skills implied by the tools/domain mentioned but not explicitly listed -- e.g. a posting listing "dbt" and "Airflow" implies SQL and basic Python fluency even if not stated.

2. Extract the Signal Behind the Words

Hard skills & tools

List every named tool, language, framework, and platform verbatim. These are your primary keyword targets for your resume's skills section and summary -- use the same terminology and acronyms the posting uses.

Seniority & scope signals

- Words like "own", "drive", "define strategy" signal a senior/lead expectation, even if the title says "Engineer II".
- Words like "support", "assist", "contribute to" signal a more junior, execution-focused scope.
- Team size, budget, or "cross-functional" mentions hint at the scope of influence expected.

Culture and values language

Recurring words like "fast-paced", "ownership", "data-driven", or "collaborative" reveal what the team values day-to-day. Mirror this language naturally in your cover letter or summary if it's genuinely true of how you work -- don't force it if it isn't.

3. Map the Job to Your Experience

Build a simple two-column mapping before you write anything:

Requirement from the JD	Your matching experience / evidence
e.g. "3+ years building ETL pipelines"	e.g. Built and maintained 5 Airflow DAGs processing 2M+ records/day at [Company]

Requirement from the JD	Your matching experience / evidence
e.g. "Experience with stakeholder communication"	e.g. Presented weekly metrics to VP-level stakeholders; translated technical findings into business recommendations
e.g. "Familiarity with cloud data warehouses"	e.g. Migrated on-prem warehouse to Snowflake, reducing query latency by 40%

Every row that's genuinely strong becomes a tailored resume bullet or a talking point for your cover letter/interview. Every row you can't fill honestly is a gap -- decide in advance how you'll address it if asked (a transferable-skill bridge, a learning plan already underway, or an honest "not yet, but here's how fast I pick things up").

4. Red Flags Worth Noticing

- A wildly long list of "required" skills spanning multiple distinct specialties often signals an under-scoped role or unrealistic expectations -- worth probing in the interview, not necessarily a reason to skip applying.
- Vague responsibilities with no clear success metric can mean the role itself is still being defined -- ask about this directly if you get an interview.
- Salary range absent where local law would otherwise require it, or a range so wide it's meaningless, is worth clarifying early to avoid wasting time.

5. Turning the Analysis Into Action

- Rewrite your resume's Core Competencies section using the JD's own terminology for skills you genuinely have.
- Reorder your bullet points within each role so the most JD-relevant achievements appear first.
- Draft 2-3 STAR stories (see the Behavioral Interview guide) that map directly to the top 3 requirements in the posting.
- If applying via a portal, paste your tailored resume and the JD into a keyword-comparison tool if one is available to catch obvious gaps before submitting.

6. Quick Worksheet

- ■ Listed all must-have vs nice-to-have requirements
- ■ Extracted exact tool/technology names and terminology
- ■ Identified seniority and scope signals
- ■ Mapped each requirement to a concrete piece of my experience
- ■ Identified my honest gaps and how I'll address them if asked
- ■ Updated resume skills/summary section with matching language
- ■ Prepared 2-3 tailored STAR stories for the top requirements

This guide reflects widely-observed hiring practices and 2025-2026 industry trends. It is general career guidance, not a guarantee of interview or offer outcomes -- always adapt advice to your specific role,

industry, and location.